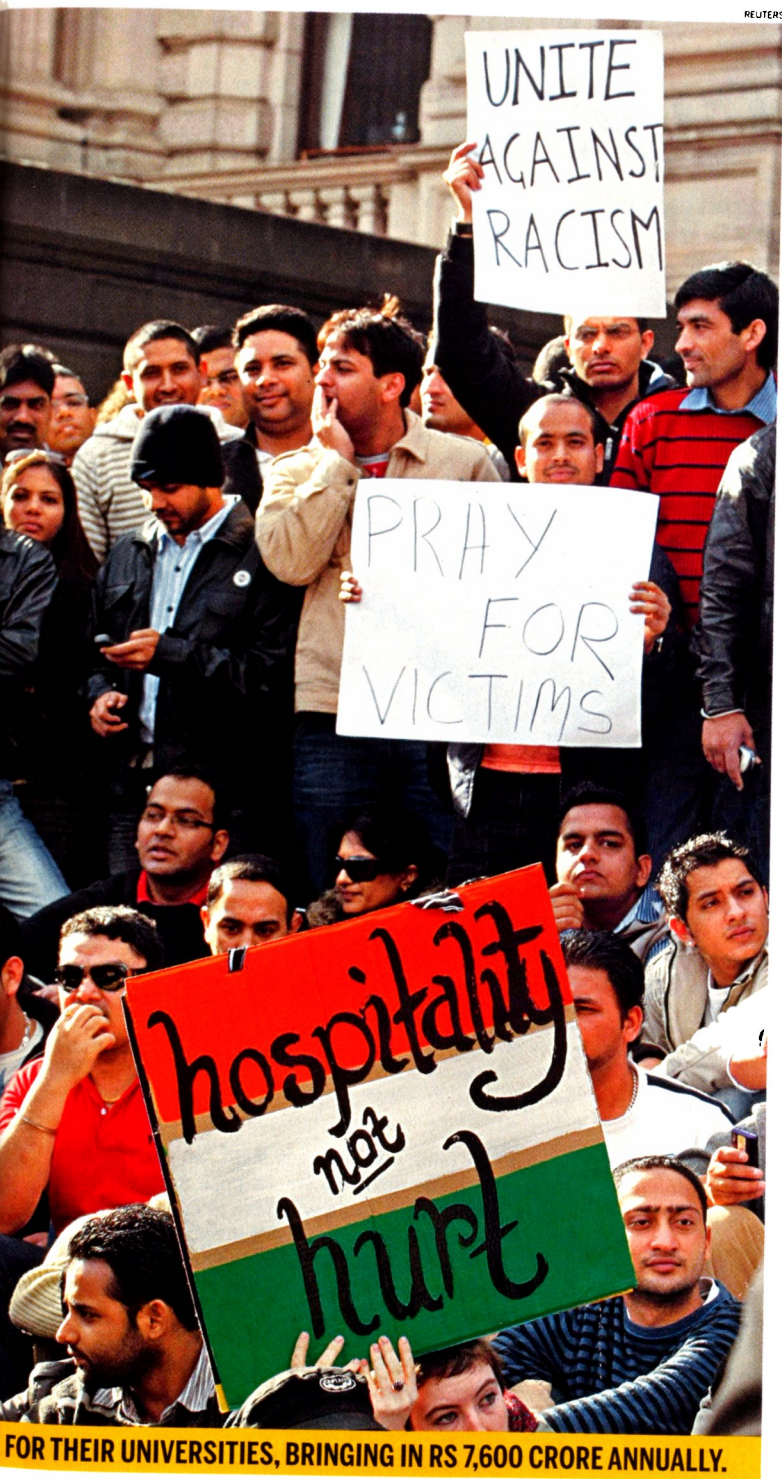




**INDIAN STUDENTS TAKE OUT
A PROTEST RALLY AGAINST
THE ATTACKS**

a swift reaction from India's best-known export—Bollywood. Even as Amitabh Bachchan's fans shaped the superstar's decision to decline an honorary doctorate from the Queensland University of Technology, the world's biggest film industry also made its feelings known. There were media reports that Indian film crews too would not work on Australian soil until the attacks on Indian students came to an end. Australian actress Tanya Zaetta, who had a role in *Salaam Namaste*, found herself playing mediator. "I understand completely Indians being upset over the recent racial attacks. I'm appalled by these myself," Zaetta said. "It makes me ashamed to be Australian when you hear about attacks on people of other cultures. But I think everyone needs to take a deep breath and calm down. Bollywood boycotting Australia will only drive the two countries further apart," she added.

Realising that the matter was getting out of hand and the damage to Australia's reputation as a centre for international education would be severe, the Australian Government moved swiftly at the highest levels of politics and law enforcement. After Manmohan's call, Rudd was quick to react. "I speak on behalf of all Australians," he said, "when I say that we deplore and condemn these attacks." The language of diplomacy aside, the Australian Government, the Victoria Government and Victoria Police all emphasised that preventing attacks is a priority. While Rudd emphasised that Indian students are "welcome guests" in this country, he was not merely using conciliatory language, but was setting in motion a viable answer to India's concerns.

The official Australian reaction has been decisive and, more importantly strong. Rob Hulls, the Victorian attorney-general, said hate crimes would be made an offence and judges would have to take into account "hatred for or prejudice against a particular group of people". The same day,